Play Hide-and-Seek With Airport Sniffer Dogs

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Would you like to play hide-and-seek with a dog at the airport and help keep people safe? The Transportation Security Administration, or TSA, is looking for volunteers to do just that.

The volunteers act as **decoys** for the TSA's dogs, which are trained to **sniff out explosives**. Each volunteer plays a '**covert role player**': a pretend passenger carrying a 'training item' around the airport. You might wait in the ticketing lobby, go through security, or sit near a gate. Then the dog team tries to sniff you out.

The TSA says a shift 'may feel like a **high-stakes** game of hide and seek.' But the game has a serious job: it keeps the dog teams ready for real work. It copies real life, so dogs stay sharp.

A shift takes about two to three hours. You need to be at least 18 to sign up on your own, but younger volunteers can join with an adult, in limited ways. You need to be happy moving around an airport; wheelchair and scooter users can take part too.

Word Treasure

decoys -- People who act as pretend passengers so the dogs can practice finding them.
explosives -- Things that can blow up and are very dangerous.
covert role player -- A person who pretends to be a passenger carrying a training item.
high-stakes -- Very important, where a lot depends on the result.
sniff out -- To find something by smelling it.

Background you need

The TSA is the group that keeps airports safe by checking passengers and bags before flights.

Its dog teams are trained to smell explosives, and they need regular practice that feels like real airport work so they stay sharp.

Volunteers help by pretending to be passengers carrying training items, so the dogs can practice finding them.

Break it down

WHO: Volunteers and the TSA's dog teams.
WHAT: Volunteers pretend to be passengers carrying training items so the dogs can practice sniffing them out.
WHERE: At airports, in places like the ticketing lobby, security and gates.
WHY: The practice keeps the dog teams ready for real work and keeps people safe.

Why it matters

It shows how a fun game of hide-and-seek can help keep everyone safe when they fly.

Test what you remember

1. What do the TSA's dogs sniff out?

- (A) Explosives
- (B) Tickets
- (C) Snacks
- (D) Lost luggage

2. What role does a volunteer play?

- (A) A pilot
- (B) A dog trainer
- (C) A covert role player
- (D) A ticket seller

3. About how long does a shift take?

- (A) About thirty minutes
- (B) About one hour
- (C) About two to three hours
- (D) About a whole day

4. How old do you need to be to sign up on your own?

- (A) At least 18
- (B) At least 16
- (C) At least 12
- (D) At least 10

5. Where might a volunteer wait during a shift?

- (A) On the runway
- (B) In the ticketing lobby
- (C) In the cockpit
- (D) In the control tower

6. Why does the TSA run this game?

- (A) To sell more tickets
- (B) To find lost dogs
- (C) To keep the dog teams ready for real work
- (D) To train new pilots

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: A 2: C 3: C 4: A 5: B 6: C

Questions to think about

1. The TSA: It says a shift may feel like a high-stakes game of hide and seek, but the game has a serious job.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):